

## Celebrate

A big technology carnival, the Digit Anniversary Carnival, is just one month away. Find out more on

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Hiking boots need to have ankle support else you risk sprains when stepping on uneven ground

## CONNECTIONS

for very basic browsing and email checking, which was about all the usage I intended for the duration of this trip. After all, holidays mean freedom from work and that means freedom from broadband. The major advantage of using a Reliance CMDA card is that the network is so extensive that no matter where you go you're never out of signal coverage range ninety per cent of the time. I'd also pack a spike guard. It's an MX unit that I bought from Lamington Road in Mumbai for 550 bucks and as asinine as this may sound, this is no ordinary spike. It's probably among the best available in India with a noise filter as well as surge protection built-in. Each of the six connects have an individual switch and the sockets can fit a variety of plugs. Most small hotels have just one plug point and having a spike also helps by providing multiple points. With my notebook, cameras, camcorder, two cellphones and GPS unit to charge, I'd make sure to make full use of its abilities. If you are shopping for a spike guard make sure it also has the ability to connect various sizes and shapes of plugs. I've been in a fix once while staying at a hotel in Bangalore for two days where I could not charge my notebook despite having available plug points in my room and my charger — make sure this doesn't happen to you.

### Friday — Answering the call of nature!

My last day at office before my vacation and I was excited. I settled down to work. During my lunch break I thought of things I had missed. Another important piece of equipment to carry with you, especially when traversing through unfrequented spots or unfamiliar territory, is a



Nokia N95 8GB — Still the convergence king



Garmin eTrex — Rugged, dependable

GPS receiver. I use a Garmin eTrex H. Check it out at <http://tinyurl.com/d4wfkv>. Sadly the unit is grossly overpriced here at around Rs. 13,000 but is available in the US for around Rs. 5,000. We owe this huge premium to the binary facts that GPS receivers are considered a novelty in India and our government's insane duties and tax structure. The eTrex H features a high sensitivity receiver that is able to lock on to signals even while under cover — such as if you're hiking through a wooded region. Its battery lasts for a good 11 hours — more than sufficient. Navigation is easy and via five buttons and the unit, besides being sturdy, is water resistant, a fact that has been tested by yours truly. It's also WAAS (wide area augmentation system) ready, which is a navigation aid that is aimed at augmenting the accuracy of GPS receivers. For those looking at something ideal for travelling by car and with inbuilt maps for navigation, look at the Garmin Nuvi 200. This beauty is priced at a pocket busting Rs. 20,000 but offers a lot for the price. It's got a wide colour display, is capable of 2D as well as 3D mapping, offers turn-by-turn voice directions as well as allowing the user to define points of interest (POI) and later gives off a proximity alert whenever a POI is near. It's SD card expandable as well. It also comes pre-loaded with the maps of India. The only downside is the battery life that lasts for around four hours real time, which means it's impractical to carry around in-hand. But plugged in to your car's charger point, you are assured not to get lost.

That evening I got ready the final few things I'd need. I packed my notebook, my PDA phone and my iPod Touch.

I also carefully packed my Grado SR 225 headphones into their box. I made sure to place the fragile stuff between denims and shirts — airport personnel are no better than the local buses in the way they throw baggage around and I certainly didn't want to damage any of my beloved possessions. I also packed a generic all-in-one battery charger I had bought off eBay India. Priced at a mere 150 bucks this charger works with all lithium-ion batteries. In case you happen to have two batteries for the same device this charger works like a charm. Imagine charging your cellphone's battery while using another battery in the device. For the interested here's a link to the product — <http://tinyurl.com/cw35d2>

What is really superb is this multi device charger from Power Traveller, called the powermonkey-eXplorer. It comes with a host of connectors for nearly every device including iPods, other PMPs, cellphones, PDAs, digital cameras, Sony's PSP, among others. The eXplorer comes with a device called the solarmonkey which basically allows the use of solar

energy to charge your devices. This killer device is a must have for road warriors — just hook up the eXplorer with the powermonkey to your backpack in the day time and it will keep charging as you trek as long as your backpack is in direct sunlight. Besides solar charging, it can also charge via AC power or a USB connect. Although expensive at close to 50 pounds or Rs. 3,700 the powermonkey-eXplorer is definitely something that goes on my wishlist. Check it out at <http://tinyurl.com/5aa7vn>. Although note that its cheaper to buy this from Amazon UK.

With all my packing done I was in readiness for the trip. I made sure to double-check everything and finally kept my e-tickets and ID inside my smaller bag that would be my cabin luggage. Before going to bed that night I had a look at all the stuff I'd be leaving behind. Sure I'd miss my gaming rig, I'd miss my HiFi headphone amplifier system and all my other stuff. I spent a couple of minutes looking at all the stuff I couldn't carry with me. I got into bed. As I was drifting off to sleep my eyes went to my packed bags stacked in the corner of my bedroom. Of its own accord a smile touched my lips even as sleep overcame me. All that I couldn't leave behind...

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SanDisk eXtreme III — Blazing fast